

Impressive counterattack: Sarfaraz Khan's maiden international hundred and 99 from wicketkeeper Rishabh Pant helped India to 462 in its second innings to give the home bowlers a small total to defend. K. MURALIKUMAR

have their refreshments. The TV broadcasters don't mind either, as they can slip in another commercial — so everybody is happy except the spectators, who, at the end of almost every Test match day, don't get to see the 90 overs they should.

Rishabh Pant is another player who doesn't possess the slim waist that these fitness purists seem to want, but what an impact player he is. Let's not forget that he also keeps wickets all day, which not only requires getting up and down for around six hours of play but also running to the stumps to gather the throws. So, please discard these yoyo-toyo tests and instead assess how strong a player is mentally. That will be a true indicator of a player's fitness. **If a player can bat the whole day or bowl 20 overs in a day, he is match-fit, regardless of how slim or not his waist is.**

Even as India plays the current series against New Zealand, some of our players are competing in the Emerging Players Asia Cup. The Ranji Trophy season has begun, and if players are being taken away to play in events like this, then the national tournament is being greatly devalued. As it is, the top international players are unavailable for the Ranji Trophy due to their international commitments, and even if a window is available, there's always the workload factor for these slim-waisted, fit players. Isn't there? So, unless they need some practice or want to get back in form, they couldn't be bothered about playing for the States from where they took their first steps in Indian cricket.

Next month, there's a needless four-match T20 series in South Africa before the tour to Australia. There will also be an 'A' team touring Australia next month, so effectively about 50 to 60 players will not be available for their State teams in the premier national tournament, the



Ranji Trophy. No other major country treats its national tournament as cavalierly as India does. Have you ever seen England or Australia hold 'A' tours or participate in meaningless events during their domestic seasons? Their domestic seasons are sacrosanct. **But ever since the IPL came along, the Ranji Trophy has sadly receded into the background.** Hopefully, this will change from the next season — or is that hoping for too much?

How often have we heard someone look at a slim-waisted individual and say how fit they are? Sports fitness doesn't depend on slim waists alone. If the mind is strong, then physical fitness can largely be controlled by it.